Friends of the Ochils

Scottish charity registration number SC 022034

ANNUAL REVIEW & FINANCIAL REPORT 2009-10

CHAIR'S REPORT 2009-10

The last year has yet again been dominated by the campaign to protect the Ochils from the damage to the landscape that would result from the Beauly to Denny powerline. In January, Minister Jim Mather gave approval for the line to go ahead, subject to Scottish Power developing proposals for visual mitigation between Cocksburn Wood and Logie, and from Logie to Glenside, that would meet the approval of Scottish Ministers, after consultation with Stirling Council. The first set of proposals put forward by Scottish Power for "informal" public consultation were woefully lacking, so a further period of campaigning is now underway to get them radically improved. There is a widespread view that ministers must now seriously reassess their earlier decision and put pressure on Scottish Power to underground at least part of their section of the line. Anything less would be regarded as a failure on the part of the Scottish Government to protect the most sensitive landscape along the whole length of the line from Beauly to Denny.

The Ochils owes a huge debt of gratitude to Nicki Baker, Peter Pearson and many others, for continuing to campaign on our behalf – a campaign made doubly difficult by the manner in which the approval decision was made by the Minister, and the total inadequacy of Scottish Power's mitigation proposals.

Unfortunately campaigning against other unacceptable developments in the Ochils has also been necessary throughout the past year. We have reported on these developments in the Newsletter but many of them have yet to be resolved.

We objected to the grid connection for Burnfoot Hill being routed down the track above Rhodders farm at Alva. Approval was nevertheless given by Clackmannanshire Council, but with stringent conditions imposed to ensure that landscape damage and the amenity of walkers is minimised. We are trying to work with the Council to ensure that the developer adheres fully to these conditions. Making sure that developers adhere to such conditions can be onerous, as those concerned with the Lochelbank windfarm application have found out since approval was given in 2007.

We have also expressed concerns to the developer about a proposed quarry in Glen Quey but they have yet to submit an application to Perth and Kinross Council. We have kept Woodland Trust Scotland and Scottish Natural Heritage aware of our concerns and will decide our response once we have seen the application.

Applications for wind turbines immediately outside the Ochils, but highly visible from them, continue to give concern. However we were pleased that the application for five turbines, each 125 metres high north-west of Saline, was refused by Fife Council whilst we await with interest the outcome of an application for a turbine, 64 metres high, to the west of Menstrie.

We formally objected to Clackmannanshire Council to this application which is a result of the recent introduction of the Feed in Tariff scheme. We can anticipate further such applications and each will have to be assessed on its merits but the height of such turbines and their impact on the landscape will be critical in determining our responses.

The problem of irresponsible wild camping in Dunning Glen has been addressed in meetings with various interested parties and it is hoped that solutions can be found which do not detract from the right to camp wild as described in the Access legislation and the Scottish Outdoor Access Code.

All Councils are in the process of drawing up new Development Plans, to replace the longstanding Structure Plans and Local Plans. The first step in this process is for the Councils to draw up Main Issues Reports, which they then put out to the public for consultation. We are responding to these as and when they are published by the three local authorities covering the Ochils. These reports form the first stage of the new Development Plans and we wish to ensure that each MIR recognises the importance of the Ochils landscape. We responded to the Stirling MIR in July and will respond in due course to those published by Clackmannanshire and Perth and Kinross Councils.

The Ochils Landscape Partnership, led by Clackmannanshire Council, passed an important milestone in September when the Heritage Lottery Fund finally awarded £631,000 funding for the project. The Friends of the Ochils has been a partner in the process of putting together the application and in developing the Hillfoots Way project in particular. We continue to work on the development of the OLP through our membership of both the 'Project Delivery' and 'Learning and Development' Task Groups, as well as helping to ensure that the governance structure for the OLP is the most appropriate for the partnership.

The Committee continues to give thought to the longer term strategy issues associated with the Ochils, and looks forward to a time when campaigning against damaging developments eases somewhat and resources can be directed at more positive developments associated with the future of the Ochils.

Meanwhile, my sincere thanks for your continued support. It greatly helps all the campaigning that we are undertaking on your behalf in these difficult times for the Friends of the Ochils.

PURPOSE AND GOVERNANCE

The objects for which Friends of the Ochils was established are identified in the Constitution (last amended November 2006):

a] To promote and conserve the landscape, natural beauty and wildlife of the Ochils, and to protect the historical and social character of the surrounding communities.

b] To encourage consistent implementation of good planning policies appropriate to the other objects of the Association.

c] To support responsible and well behaved public access to the Ochils consistent with the Scottish Outdoor Access Code.

d] To promote appropriate study of and research into relevant fields of interest pertaining to the Ochils and its local communities, and to promote dissemination of the results of such study and research.

Committee members are elected from the membership for a 3-year period at the AGM, or may be co-opted. Nominations are sought through the Newsletter and at the AGM. The Committee members constitute the Trustees with responsibility for governance consistent with Scottish charity law and regulations. Office bearers are elected by the Committee. Policy and strategy are agreed at regular Committee meetings: five were held in 2009-10. Within agreed strategic frameworks, operational discretion is delegated to specific Committee members leading on particular activities.

COMMITTEE (TRUSTEES)

			Year of initial election	*Current period of office*
President Rennie McOwan	Stirling		n/a	n/a
Chair Stuart Dean	Viewfield Muckhart FK14 7JN	01259 781551 spdean@lineone.net	2005	2008-11
Vice Chair, Treasurer, Membership Secretary Dr Nicki Baker	Parkhead Logie Stirling FK9 4LS	01786 833399 nicki.baker@btinternet.com	2005	2008-11
Secretary David Scott	Bridge of Allan	01786 832248 dcbscott@tiscali.co.uk	2008	2008-11
Website Secretary Dave Prentice	Tibbermore, Perth	01738 583345 dave_prentice@btinternet.com	2002	2008-11
Catherine Kilgour	Stirling	07970 821 483 catkilgour@hotmail.com	2007	2007-10
Fenwick Worrell	Glendevon		2007	2007-10

The committee always welcomes new members, and will be pleased to hear from any member wishing to join. To stand for election at the AGM, potential committee members must be proposed and seconded by other members of the organisation.

MEMBERSHIP REPORT

Membership of the Friends of the Ochils has stayed very stable for another year, and we end the year, as last year, with 182 Life, Family, Individual and Concession members, plus 8 Group members. A small number of people (10) who did not renew their membership was balanced by new members, whom we are pleased to welcome to our organisation.

As reported in the Annual Report for 2008/09, the Committee had intended to make significant efforts to increase the profile of the Friends of the Ochils in 2010, and with it the number of members we have, but once again the number of important issues on which we have had to focus our attentions has meant we needed to postpone this drive.

As always, we would very much welcome having more people on the Committee, and if this were to happen, we would find it easier to work on increasing the membership numbers.

Membership at 31 August 2010

	2000	**2003**	**2005**	**2006**	**2007**	**2008**	**2009**	**2010**
Honorary Life	-	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
Life	15	14	15	14	17	17	16	18
Family	28	25	32	34	34	30	32	33
Individual	44	44	57	61	61	56	56	53
Concession	39	38	39	42	42	38	45	44
(Total personal)*	**(154)**	**(145)**	**(175)**	**(185)**	**(189)**	**(177)**	**(182)**	**(182)**
Community	6	6	5	7	7	8	8	8
Corporate	1	-	-	-	-	-	-	-

* Each Family members counts as 2 people.

With the finances once more showing a small surplus for the year, the Committee recommends leaving subscriptions unchanged for 2011-12, at £3 for concessions, £5 for individuals, £7.50 for families and £15 for groups.

FINANCE REPORT 2009-2010

The accounting period runs from 1 September to 31 August. The table below shows income and expenditure during the year 2009-10, the year end position and a comparison with the previous financial year. The annual accounts are examined independently, by Dr Brian Jamieson (Logie), and have been approved by him without qualification.

Income exceeded expenditure by £168 in 2009-10, with approximately £100 still to be collected. The organisation's assets were £4,686 at the end of the year, with a sum of £2,148 still remaining available for future campaigning work.

Accounts for year 1 September 2009 to 31 August 2010 (1)

	2009-10		**2008-09**
INCOME	**£**		**£**
Subscriptions	848.00	(2)	831.00
Donations	110.00		105.00
Gift Aid	137.61		126.06
Bank interest	116.69	(3)	208.35
TOTAL	**1,212.30**		**1,270.41**
EXPENDITURE			
On charitable objects			
Landscape campaigning	128.80		352.30
Publicity: newsletter & annual review	410.86		359.97
Publicity: website	338.76		314.38
leaflets	-		446.98
On administration			
General administration	165.71		151.68
TOTAL	**1,044.13**		**1,625.31**
SURPLUS (DEFICIT) FOR YEAR	**168.17**		**(354.90)**
ADD Balance at 31 August 2009	4,518.46		4,873.36
BALANCE AT 31 AUGUST 2010	**4,686.63**		**4,518.46**
REPRESENTED BY:			
Bank of Scotland current account	467.10		415.07
Standard Life Bank 10-day community account	4,219.53		4,103.39
NET ASSETS	**4,686.63**	(4)	**4,518.46**

Notes to the accounts

(1) Accounts are prepared on an income and expenditure basis.

(2) Concession members paying by standing order continued to pay £2, for one final year. Requests to renew Group membership were sent out late, and only 2 renewals were received by 31 August.

(3) Interest on our deposits in the Standard Life Bank is paid annually in September. The sum declared for 2009-10 reflects the crash in interest rates, whereas the previous year's interest largely predated this.

(4) Friends of the Ochils owns a Reflecta Classic slide projector and Sopar projection screen (bought August 2000, at a cost of £190). Both are treated as having nil current value.

- No remuneration was paid to any Committee member or any relative of a Committee member.
- Expenses are paid to Committee members only in respect of verifiable costs incurred on behalf of Friends of the Ochils.

Signed:

For and on behalf of the Committee, *Dr Nicki Baker (Treasurer)*	**29th October 2010**	Independent examiner, *Dr Brian Jamieson, Blairlogie*